

JEFF STURGIS

DEER HUNTING METHODOLOGY

Mindset · Habitat Design · Routes · Food · Pressure · Stands

A detailed compilation of how Jeff Sturgis — founder of Whitetail Habitat Solutions — thinks about mature whitetails: parcel design as a hunting machine, the three food-plot jobs, doe bedding tight to screened food, buck bedding behind the doe layer, defined daylight hallways, hidden access, and the doctrine that hunting pressure is the lowest hole in the bucket.

THE SIX-STEP OPERATING SYSTEM

1. Design the hunt first. Access, stands, and pressure beat seed.
2. Separate destination food from the hallway you will actually sit.
3. Screen the edge so does bed tight to food and bucks slide behind them.
4. Pin the hallway with one scrape per stand and water between dry beds and food.
5. Enter and leave on the dead side. Never walk the cafeteria.
6. Sit the defined path — water, bench, staging — more than the plot itself.

Prepared for Casey Summerlin · Anson County, North Carolina
September 9, 2026

Drawn from Sturgis's public writing, Whitetail Habitat Solutions classes and videos, MeatEater / Outdoor Life / Wired to Hunt interviews, and published talks. Not a substitute for his books, web classes, or a paid habitat design. HuntBrief's locked terrain engine remains Brad Herndon.

Contents

1. Who Jeff Sturgis Is — and Why His System Matters
2. The Core Mindset
3. The Lowest Hole in the Bucket
4. How He Plans a Parcel — Order of Operations
5. Food Philosophy — Three Plot Jobs and Five Feedings
6. Cover, Screens, and Depth of Cover
7. Bedding — Does First, Bucks Behind Them
8. Paths, Routes, and the Daylight Conveyor
9. Stand Assemblage
10. Waterholes and Mock Scrapes
11. Wind, Hills, and Thermals
12. The Seasonal Calendar
13. Public Land — Same Brain, No Dozer
14. Huntisms He Is Trying to Kill
15. The Six-Step Operating System
16. Applying This Thinking on the Anson County Farm
17. Sturgis vs. Herndon vs. Higgins
18. Sources and How to Go Deeper

This document is a field study, not a reprint of Sturgis's books or web classes and not a how-to for illegal activity. Tactics are compiled from material he has published or spoken about publicly through 2026. HuntBrief uses Brad Herndon as the locked terrain engine. Sturgis is complementary habitat, access, and pressure logic.

1. Who Jeff Sturgis Is — and Why His System Matters

Jeff Sturgis is a Michigan-raised, now Minnesota-based whitetail habitat designer, bowhunter, author, and teacher. He founded Whitetail Habitat Solutions (WHS) in 2005 and has spent two decades walking client farms — well over a thousand parcels across roughly 26 states — then drawing a hunt-first design before he leaves the property.

He did not come from a hunting family. In 1985 he and his brother asked for bows for Christmas. He learned squirrels in southern Michigan oaks, stumbled into his first deer, and field-dressed it from a magazine. First out-of-state bowhunt was Indiana in 1988. Since then he has hunted public and private ground in Michigan, Pennsylvania, Ohio, Wisconsin, Indiana, Kentucky, Minnesota, and elsewhere, often several states a year. He still hunts a Pennsylvania big-woods public area he has used since 1993.

In 2004 he received QDMA's (now National Deer Association) Al Brothers Deer Manager of the Year award. His first Quality Whitetails article ran in spring 2004. Books in the Whitetail Success by Design line followed, including Whitetail Success by Design (2012) and Food Plot Success by Design (2014); WHS materials describe a five-book set plus web classes on parcel design, food plots, the rut, and hills/thermals. He competed at a high level in 3D archery in the late 1990s and early 2000s, including national titles in Open and Semi-Pro.

The business is a family shop. Partners and specialists have included Jen, Dylan Lenz, Joe Youngblood, Kevan Smith, and Weston Meyers. The YouTube channel and WHS podcast are the public classroom; the paid product is an

on-the-ground design that treats each farm as a one-off puzzle.

He is useful to HuntBrief for a different reason than Herndon. Herndon tells you which landform a daylight buck will use. Sturgis tells you whether your food, screens, walking routes, and sit choices are ruining that landform before you climb. He is a habitat architect whose first loyalty is the hunt, not the seed bag.

2. The Core Mindset

Sturgis does not think like a “plant it and they will come” hunter. He thinks like an engineer whose job is to make daylight movement obvious, then disappear on the edge of that movement.

“You can have too much food, and you can have too much cover. There’s a great balance of both.”

— Jeff Sturgis, MeatEater Wired to Hunt

“The more you can define that movement, then you can go hunt. And not the other way around.”

— Jeff Sturgis, on parcel design

“Ultimately, the lowest hole in the bucket is hunting pressure. And there’s no amount of quality habitat that can overcome that.”

— Jeff Sturgis, MeatEater Wired to Hunt

Five beliefs he actually hunts by

- **You design movement. You do not wait for it.** Food, cover, water, and screens are placed so deer take the same daylight path. Stands go on that path.
- **Balance beats more.** Extra plots and extra thicket both fail when they are not linked. An improvement that does not support the rest of the farm should not be built.
- **Mature bucks are grumpy old men.** Does bed close to food. Older bucks push behind that doe layer into quieter cover. Destination food in the middle of the back 40 steals the only room a mature buck had to hide in daylight.
- **Most parcels cannot hold a buck’s whole life.** Even several hundred acres often is not a full home range. The design steals daylight hours from neighboring ag, timber, or public — then releases deer after dark so they do not linger on high-risk spots.
- **The hunt is designed into the dirt.** “You have to develop the habitat as if you’re going to hunt the habitat.” Planting without access, wind, and stand logic is how pretty farms go nocturnal.

He is blunt about gadgets and moon charts. Experience does not fast-forward. There is no seed mix, scent product, or calendar widget that outruns how you walk the farm. He pays limited attention to moon as a feeding-timing nudge (bright rising moon can push evening movement later and juice late morning the next day) and almost none as a rut trigger. Cold fronts, the dinner feed, and whether you educated the hallway matter more.

3. The Lowest Hole in the Bucket

This is the sentence that organizes everything else. Habitat quality cannot save bad access, a stupid stand, or too many sits. Worse: better habitat can hurt you. High-quality food and cover pull more deer onto a farm you then educate. If you are going to hunt sloppy — ATV loops, walking plots, sitting the cafeteria three evenings a week — he has said you are often better doing nothing to the land. Unimproved dirt at least does not advertise the neighborhood onto a trap they learn.

He has watched clients pour money into plots, then ride a Ranger through them until daylight activity dies. He has watched a 400-acre cover block in Ohio pasture country sit empty because the owner drove the property daily. Pressure is not only “hunting days.” It is every human hour on the dirt — cameras checked loud, food-plot maintenance at noon, shed walks through beds in February that you could have saved for March edges.

Corollary: the more attractive you make the farm, the more disciplined the hunt must become. Attraction without stealth produces a night herd. That is why his designs start with how you walk, not with what you plant.

4. How He Plans a Parcel — Order of Operations

Not “pretty plots first.” On a consult he interviews the hunter about what is failing, walks the dirt, and draws the puzzle so the pieces support each other. The working order, assembled from his talks and from client plan breakdowns, looks like this:

Order	Piece	Why it comes here
1	Hunter access	If you cannot enter and leave clean, every other improvement is a night-light for educated deer.
2	Food locations	Food can only live where it does not sit on the walking route. Access decides where food is allowed.
3	Stand locations	Morning, evening, and all-day trees for specific winds — hung after access and food are honest.
4	Mock scrape per stand	One scrape per sit. Scarcity keeps the pin valuable. Not fifty scrapes on one trail.
5	Waterholes	Fewer than scrapes. Between dry bedding and food, not inside the holding plot.
6	Screening	Switchgrass, willow, dogwood, hinge — so the walk and the stand disappear.
7	Doe bedding	Tight to screened food. Does want to bed as close to dinner as security allows.
8	Buck bedding	Behind the doe layer — quieter, often uphill or isolated, with browse in the bed.
9	Timber / TSI / hinge	Last. Shape timber to the hunt map. Do not let the logger invent the bedding.

Access determines where food can live. Food determines where you are not allowed to walk. Stands come after both. He treats property layout like hang-a-stand logic at farm scale: approach, wind, neighbors, time of day, time of year — not “best soil” or “prettiest oak.”

West-to-east access is a frequent preference when the ground allows it, but it is not a religion. Horizontal farms get north and south trails that protect the heart. Vertical farms keep exterior access and refuse to punch a road through the sanctuary. Corners that dump neighbor pressure onto you are assets if you own the funnel they create.

Biggest layout sins he keeps seeing: bedding defined by a timber rotation instead of by the hunter; food butted against beds so deer step from bed to plot in forty yards and you cannot sit either; walk-through plots on the way to stands; clover that is dead in November; too much cover with no defined approach; hanging over “perfect soil” with obvious access.

5. Food Philosophy — Three Plot Jobs and Five Feedings

Sturgis sells seed and wrote the food-plot book. He still tells clients they hunt plots too much. In one widely quoted season he shot four bow bucks in four states and none of them died on a food plot. Clients spending ninety percent of sits on plots both under-kill and educate the farm. Food plots have the greatest potential reward and the greatest risk.

The three jobs

Mixing these jobs is how farms go nocturnal. A kill plot that acts like a destination makes deer linger until dark, which means you cannot enter or leave.

Type	Job	Feel	Hunt it?
Destination	Night cafeteria. Holding power November through winter. Neighbor ag often plays this role.	Bigger. Last stop before dark. Brassica, grain, leftover ag.	Rarely. Highest reward and highest risk.
Holding	Keep deer on your dirt until dark, then release them to destination food — your big plot or the neighbor's beans.	Medium. Screened. Should still have food at last light.	Carefully. Do not add water or a scrape here — that ruins the on-the-way sit.
Hunt / kill	A window on movement. Short stop, then they keep going.	Narrow — he has described plots only fifteen yards wide. Greens, not corn.	Yes — if they do not linger forty-five minutes and eat it to dirt.

A kill plot is not a kill plot unless it is on the way to something else. Dead-end plots fail. He would rather delete a pretty plot than keep spooking it. Linked improvements only: a small plot with a waterhole seventy-five yards behind it, bedding behind that, and major food ahead is a system. A lone square in an opening is not.

Summer food versus fall food

This is herd strategy, not agronomy. Add summer food and you raise the population — does and fawns pile on. Strip summer food and those family groups live next door in July and slide onto you in September and October. A two-hundred-acre farm with twenty acres of beans and a hundred does is, to him, a buck problem. Mature bucks do not want that commotion. He would rather those does summer elsewhere and the farm become a fall magnet instead of a July nursery.

November forage is the carrying-capacity month. Clover and chicory that die in fall fail the test. Small parcels with one or two acres of food must prioritize hunter-season months, not May wallpaper. In big woods he and students have used a working figure of roughly ten to fifteen percent of the tract in food if you want true holding power — with the warning that a plot punched into the only sanctuary destroys depth of cover.

Five feedings in twenty-four hours

This is how he times sits. Deer feed about five times a day:

- **Feedings 1–2:** browse in or near bedding — late morning and early afternoon. Light, local, often missed by hunters who only sit last light.
- **Feeding 3:** the dinner feed, about an hour before dark. Highest-value clock of the day. Every deer that can will try to make this appointment.
- **Feedings 4–5:** night, often on big ag, fencerows, and destination fields. Fence-row beds beside a bean field are usually midnight beds, not evening stands.

Miss feeding three because of a slamming evening storm and they make it up later or the next morning inside cover. That is why a washed-out dinner can set up a high-value late-morning sit. A bright rising moon can push evening movement later and shift more feeding into late morning. He uses that. He does not build a season around moon-phase tables.

No perfect plot shape. Do not force a square peg into a round hole. Location is trees, existing movement, timing of use, and hunter access — not soil vanity. Wet and shady plots are hard. Linear plots that follow movement beat blobs dropped on any opening.

6. Cover, Screens, and Depth of Cover

Screening is the first line of security. A strip of switchgrass, silky or hybrid willow, gray dogwood, or hinge along a plot edge lets does bed twenty to thirty yards off the food instead of a hundred and fifty yards back in open hardwoods. You look into their world. They do not look into yours.

“Screening sets up that first line of security to deer to where they now feel comfortable bedding 30 yards into the cover from the food plot.”

— Jeff Sturgis

Depth of cover is how far a buck can get from food and pressure and still feel boxed in with escape options. Punch a destination plot into the middle of the back forty and you shrink that depth. As bucks age, daylight range shrinks and shifts to more remote settings. Does take the near-food beds; the older buck takes the recess. Fragment the recess with extra openings and he lives next door.

Switchgrass is his cheap converter. Turn a front field you used to spook into a tunnel you walk through to a deeper sit. On his Minnesota farm he frost-seeded former plots to switchgrass specifically so he could pass them without bumping deer — then hunt a corner stand looking down onto a cruising bench. Forty-foot grass strips become firearm-season tunnels and morning back doors.

Bedding size is matched to how far a deer can see, how many escape routes exist, and how many deer you have — not “thicker is always better.” Thick with no defined approach is just a place you bump them. An effective bedding area has to be screened from your walk. A twenty-acre bed is not twenty acres if they can see, hear, or smell you coming.

7. Bedding — Does First, Bucks Behind Them

This is the most Sturgis idea on the page, and it is the one most “plant a sanctuary in the back” farms get backwards.

Doe bedding

Does want to bed as close to evening food as security allows. Give them screened cover on the plot edge. That is the doe-bedding plan. Pull doe and fawn beds off distant benches and stick them against the screened food. Once does own the near-food edge, you have set the table for bucks.

Buck bedding

Bucks bed behind that doe layer — further, quieter, often uphill, on a point, bench, or isolated pocket. The bed itself needs browse (hinge plus willow or poplar plus residual stems). A “buck bedding area” with no nearby doe bedding and no food alignment is just brush. He builds with whatever the land already offers:

- Hinge-cut pockets and a “maze” effect so a buck can hide and leave in more than one direction.
- Aspen or early-successional pockets with high stem count after a tight cut.
- Conifers for thermal cover when the weather turns.
- Uneven-age timber and dropped canopy rather than a sterile park of mature hardwoods.
- Isolated pockets off the main doe traffic so the oldest buck is not living in the nursery.

Sex segregation is the point. Same total food and cover, but split so bucks are not living in the fawn pile. That forces bucks to move between hotspots — which is what you hunt. Mature does run the near-food beds except in cover-starved ag regions where everyone is desperate.

He refuses to let timber stand improvement invent the beds. Define the bed from interior and exterior influences — neighbors, access, food, wind — then shape the cutting to that map. Keep a strip of adjacent mature timber when you can. It becomes a downwind blocker and a deer-proof walk to the tree.

8. Paths, Routes, and the Daylight Conveyor

Think of a Sturgis farm as a one-way daylight conveyor, not a buffet with chairs around it.

Buck bed → water + mock scrape → kill / hunt plot → holding plot → destination food after dark.

Hunter access runs parallel, on the downwind or “dead” side, screened the entire way.

Hunter paths — your routes

- Perimeter first. Protect the heart. Do not cut a two-track through the sanctuary unless the tract is huge.
- Tunnels of switchgrass or willow so you never silhouette on a field.
- Back-door morning entries on points, ditches, or the empty side of a ridge.
- Downwind blocked by a field, river, pasture, road, or open hardwoods you do not need.
- Never walk the food after the sit. If the only exit is across the plot, the plot is in the wrong place.
- Hide inner trails. Planting along a two-track is acceptable only if that trail is already low-spook and screened.

Deer paths — their routes

- Defined corridors: hinge both sides of an existing trail so it becomes a hallway, not a suggestion.
- Linear plots that follow existing movement instead of squares dropped on open dirt.
- Water and scrape as pins on the hallway.
- Staging thirty to eighty yards off food, not in the open plot.
- In hills: benches, saddles, points, top flats, bottom flats. He discards steep “tight contour” ground — deer spend energy there only when they must.
- Do not put water or a mock scrape in a holding or destination plot. That collapses the on-the-way sit into one high-risk blob.

He is not trying to send deer around the farm on a carousel. He is trying to create one honest daily movement you can intercept without bumping the bed or the cafeteria. Mineral sites and subtle cuttings can steer a transition. The test is simple: can you draw the afternoon path on a map and hang a tree on it that you can reach without the deer knowing?

9. Stand Assemblage

He does not hang “a good tree.” He hangs a set of stands that cover one movement for different clocks and winds. Call it an assemblage: several trees, one hallway, many legal days.

Clock	Where the tree lives	What it is watching
Evening	Edge of doe bedding / staging. Cover at your back.	Kill plot or the first thirty yards of the holding plot. Dinner feed.

Clock	Where the tree lives	What it is watching
Morning	Backside of buck bedding. You are not walking into food.	Bucks returning to bed. Often a waterhole on that return line.
All-day / rut	Water + scrape on a bench, saddle, or cruising line.	Daylight travel. Water is permission to sit midday.
Firearm	Screened field edge or grass tunnel with a back door.	Last light on destination food you refused to bowhunt all October.

He scores stands by when they work. Some trees are a two-percent chance in early season and a twenty-five-percent chance at peak. You do not burn the twenty-five-percent tree in October because you were bored. Define trail access first; the tree is useless if the walk ruins it.

Place the stand on the edge of the cover that creates the movement. Open hardwoods between the bed and the tree will not get used — deer will not cross a hundred yards of park timber to visit your oak. Most of his bow stands sit tight to the security cover, often with the stand itself behind a screen so the climb does not flash to the plot. He has described relatively low stands — mid-teens — when cover hides the body.

If you are not hunting on food, you are hunting off to the side: a waterhole, a cruising bench, a mock scrape inside bow range. That is the theme of his own Minnesota farm tour. The lowest hole is still how the land is hunted.

10. Waterholes and Mock Scrapes

These are pins, not decorations. They exist to make an existing hallway stop in front of a tree.

Mock scrapes

One mock scrape per stand location. Not one per acre. Not a line of twenty. Scarcity keeps value high. Build on a flat near the trail you already expect them to use. Vine or licking branch about three-quarters of an inch to an inch, five to eight feet of hanging length depending on how open the spot is. People ask how far from the plot or the water. His answer is the same: one per stand. The scrape belongs to the tree.

Waterholes

Fewer than scrapes. On a fifty- to sixty-acre farm with eleven stands he might run two to four waterholes, more only when elevation keeps drainages from sharing one hole. A buck will not usually climb four hundred feet and drop back down for a drink. He will hit water on the way from a dry bed to dinner.

Place water between dry bedding and food — or between bedding areas on a cruising line. Do not drop a tub in the holding plot. That wrecks the all-day sit. Early season heat makes water a better daylight stand than the plot. Pre-rut and rut, use picks up in mid-morning and early afternoon. After a night on greens they often skip water on the way back to bed, which is another reason morning trees belong on the backside, not on the cafeteria.

Build so it looks like ground, not hardware. He moved from proud-of-the-lip tubs (does stomped and stared) to burying barrels or half-barrels at or below grade, saucered to collect water, sometimes cut into a slight hill. Natural and self-filling beats a shiny tank.

Ideal chain on one movement: water + scrape, then a kill plot, then a holding plot. That lengthens the line, adds trees, and gives you more winds. Each attraction is separated so one sit does not burn the next.

11. Wind, Hills, and Thermals

Sturgis teaches a full hills-and-thermals class. The practical rules are simple even if the dirt is not.

- Hunt elevation plus time of day, not compass wind alone.
- Morning thermals fall. Evening thermals rise. Sit so scent dumps into a ditch, field, or dead side — not the bed.
- Get off the ground. “Clean air above the soil” lets scent ride over a bed instead of pooling into it.
- Lee side of a ridge in high wind: deer pile on the quiet face. Still-hunt finger ridges, peek a bench, back out, repeat.
- Nasty, cold, snow: start high on saddles and points, then drop thirty to forty feet to watch an upper bowl. Freeze, still-hunt, sit again.
- Hemlock and other conifer lines in the bottoms are the thermal bunker when it is ugly.
- Valleys are hard. Points and mid-slope benches are the percentage play.
- Food decides where they bed on a hill. Does pull toward the food face; bucks take the next recess behind them.

His four topo features for e-scouting: bench systems (the giant sitting on the side of the ridge — contour lines suddenly widen), ridge systems and points, saddles (the low spot on an otherwise consistent ridge), and flats on top or in the bottom. Tight contours are work. Deer avoid extra work in daylight.

This is the closest he gets to Herndon. Same nouns — saddle, bench, point. Different use. Herndon finds them on a raw map and hunts the choke. Sturgis also builds screens and food so those features get used every afternoon, then hangs the assemblage on the defined path.

12. The Seasonal Calendar

Early season

Heat and water between dry beds and food. Velvet and September water can beat the plot. Do not hammer destination food. Pattern the conveyor. Hunt the window, not the night field. Summer camera bucks that vanish in October often vanished because you — or the previous hunter — sat the cafeteria and walked the access they were using.

October

Kill plots and staging. Older bucks often avoid doe commotion on big food. Hunt the woods side. Save the best rut trees. Doe harvest, if you take one, is surgical — not a Saturday drive-around that blows the machine.

Rut

He teaches the rut as a roughly forty-five-day window, not a seven-day holiday. Water, scrapes, and benches earn all-day sits. “Score the sit”: a morning tree and an evening tree as two different plays on one high-value day. Weather rollercoasters matter more than moon-phase posters. Cold front after slop, rising high pressure, blue skies — that is the sit. Playing poker in the rut woods means you do not shove every chip onto one plot at 4 p.m.

Late season

Destination and holding food finally become the hunt — if you did not educate them all fall. Cold plus south slopes plus conifer thermal plus whatever brassica or grain is left. Public-land version: lee faces, hemlock line, still-hunt when the wind is too loud to sit still.

13. Public Land — Same Brain, No Dozer

He still kills public-land bucks. Pennsylvania since 1993. Upper Michigan. Ohio. The translation of the private-land machine:

- Delete hunter parking, steep unused slope, and bland identical hardwoods.
- Keep habitat edges: clearcut against timber against swamp, long benches, saddles, points, flats top and bottom.
- Hunt between diversity, not in the middle of ten thousand identical acres. Hills dictate that most movement lives on a small fraction of the cover.
- Sit travel. Still-hunt lee faces when the wind is ugly. Move when someone is in “your” spot.
- Cameras live on the stand feature, not on random oaks.
- Public next to private food is a backside-morning gift — same “release after dark” idea. You just did not plant the destination field.
- South-facing slopes plus lowland conifer is a winter and shed combo worth remembering for November and March.

In twenty-two seasons on one Pennsylvania public area he has described taking eighteen bucks. The method is terrain, patience, weather, and the willingness to walk. One of his huntisms is that other hunters do not automatically ruin a public spot if you can relocate. Flexibility is the public-land screen you cannot plant.

14. Huntisms He Is Trying to Kill

After enough client interviews the same bad ideas show up. He calls them huntisms — misconceptions that cost seasons.

Huntism	What he actually believes
You can't kill them from the couch.	Do the map work from the couch so you do not burn the farm scouting. Then go. Couch work is not the hunt. It is how the hunt stays clean.
More food plots mean more big bucks.	More summer food means more does. More hunted plots mean more night deer. Balance and unpressured fall food beat acreage.
The best way to kill a big buck is to wait on a food plot.	Most of his bow bucks die off-plot — water, bench, woods funnel on the way. Plots are a tool, not a chair.
Other hunters will ruin your public spot.	Move. Hunt a different feature, a different clock, a different wind. Public success is flexibility plus terrain.
Plant every opening.	Openings that sit on access or steal depth of cover are liabilities. Linked improvements only.
Thicker is always better.	Thick with no approach and no stand is a bump zone. Define the bed, then thicken it.
Moon phase runs the rut.	He mostly ignores moon as a trigger. Feeding-timing nudge, yes. Rut calendar, no.
If the habitat is good enough, hunting style won't matter.	Opposite. Better habitat magnifies sloppy hunting. Pressure is the lowest hole.

15. The Six-Step Operating System

Compressed into a pocket card you can run on any farm, including Anson County:

- **1. Design the hunt first.** Draw access, stands, and dead space before you draw seed. The lowest hole is how the land is hunted.
- **2. Separate the cafeteria from the hallway.** Destination food holds them at night. Kill plots and staging are the daylight window. Do not make one spot do both jobs.
- **3. Screen the edge.** Does bed tight to food. Bucks slide behind that layer. If they can see you walk in, it is not a bed.
- **4. Pin the hallway.** One scrape per stand. Water between dry beds and food. Do not put either pin in the holding plot.
- **5. Enter and leave on the dead side.** Perimeter, grass tunnel, back door, downwind blocked. Never walk the food.
- **6. Sit the defined path more than the plot.** Water, bench, staging, backside of the buck bed. Save destination food for the sit that actually deserves it.

If any piece is missing — sloppy access, a plot you have to cross, a stand that only works if deer wait for you in the open — fix the piece. Do not hang another tree on a broken machine.

16. Applying This Thinking on the Anson County Farm

Locked HuntBrief facts: 308.44 acres in Anson County, North Carolina (35.076243, -80.193882). Large ag fields locked as soybeans for 2026. Blue circles are fall food plots. Orange pins are the thirteen named stands. Terrain engine is Brad Herndon — points, saddles, benches, inside corners, creek and fencerow funnels, hilltop field funnels, converging hubs, breaklines.

Official stand list: Pine Thicket Stand, Braswell Back, Braswell Midway, Papa Bob Stand, GaGa Woods Stand, Upper Food Plot, Lower Food Plot, Upper Creeks Stand, Martys Stand, Papa Darin Stand, Drews Stand, Bottom Creek Stand, Papa Bobs Hill.

What Sturgis would ask on day one

- **Are the soybeans the destination?** Yes. Treat them like his neighbor-ag night cafeteria. They are feeding 4 and 5, not the bow sit you burn every October evening.
- **Are the blue fall plots holding plots or kill plots?** If they are large and you sit in the open over them, you are hunting destination food in October and training nights. Split the job: a narrow, screened hunt plot on the way, a holding plot that still has food at dark, beans after dark.
- **Can you reach Pine Thicket, GaGa Woods, the creek stands, and Papa Bobs Hill without crossing beans or a plot?** If not, those stands fail his first test no matter how good the Herndon feature is.
- **Where is doe bedding relative to plots and bean corners?** It should tighten to the screened edge — switchgrass, dogwood, hinge, whatever will hide a bed twenty to thirty yards off food.
- **Where is buck bedding?** Behind that doe layer: pine thicket, creek benches, points, the hill. That is already Herndon language. Sturgis just insists the doe layer exists first.
- **Water + one scrape per stand on the way from creek and pine beds to beans.** That is the add-on, not a new stand map. Keep water out of the holding plot so all-day creek and bench sits stay honest.
- **Summer bean acreage on 308 acres will load does.** That is a herd-density choice. If the farm feels like a nursery in July, fall buck daylight will suffer. Sturgis would rather see those family groups summer somewhere else and

slide in when the plots and mast matter.

Practical mapping onto named stands, without changing the locked list: Upper and Lower Food Plot are the high-risk pair — treat them as holding or last-light only, and hunt the staging off to the side. Upper Creeks, Bottom Creek, and the Braswell line are hallway and water sits. Pine Thicket and GaGa Woods are the doe-to-buck bedding stack if screens exist on the plot edge. Papa Bobs Hill and Papa Bob Stand are morning backside / point / thermal plays. Drews, Martys, and Papa Darin live or die on whether the walk is clean for the day’s wind.

Herndon still picks the choke. Sturgis decides whether your food, screens, and walking routes are allowed to exist next to that choke. If the two disagree, access and pressure win. A perfect saddle you have to cross beans to reach is not a Sturgis sit and, on a pressured day, is not a Herndon sit either.

17. Sturgis vs. Herndon vs. Higgins

Question	Herndon	Higgins	Sturgis
First move	Read the map. Mark chokes.	Build a zero-intrusion sanctuary.	Draw access, then food, then stands.
What he hunts	Saddle, bench, point, inside corner, hub, breakline.	One wind-specific tree on the sanctuary edge.	The defined hallway: staging, water, backside of the buck bed.
Food’s job	A reason deer move through the choke.	Keep the buck living on you. Don’t hunt the plot.	Three jobs. Destination at night. Kill plot as a window.
Pressure	Enter off the field. Leave clean. Don’t skyline.	Almost religious. Stay home if the piece is wrong.	Lowest hole in the bucket. Better habitat magnifies sloppy hunts.
Wind	First filter. Hunt high. Dump scent to dead space.	Play it the way the buck plays it. Tree is wind-specific.	Compass plus thermals plus lee side. Elevation and clock.
When to go	When the choke has a legal wind.	Temperature, front, history, same-time same-place.	Dinner feed, fronts, defined movement. Moon as a nudge only.
Public land	Same terrain library.	Harder to build sanctuary. Discipline still applies.	Same brain. Hunt edges of diversity. Move when pressured.
HuntBrief role	Locked terrain engine.	When-to-go and sanctuary discipline.	Habitat layout, plot jobs, access, pressure diagnosis.

They stack. Herndon answers where the feet will fall. Higgins answers whether you should leave the house and whether the buck still lives on you. Sturgis answers whether the farm’s food and walking routes are feeding those two systems or fighting them.

18. Sources and How to Go Deeper

This field study is compiled from Sturgis’s public record, not from a private consult. Primary places he has put the system in his own words:

- Whitetail Habitat Solutions — about page, parcel-layout blog (2012), food-plot and parcel-design web classes, hills-and-thermals class, WHS podcast.
- Books: Whitetail Success by Design (2012), Food Plot Success by Design (2014), and later titles in the design series including All Weather Whitetails as referenced in class bundles.
- MeatEater Wired to Hunt: “How Jeff Sturgis Makes Easy Land Improvements for Whitetails”; Ep. 331 Back 40 walk-through; Ep. 729 late season; Cutting the Distance habitat episode.
- Outdoor Life podcast (December 2024): “What We Get Wrong About Whitetails” — the huntisms interview.

- Farm-tour and how-to videos: Minnesota deer farm tour; kill-plot versus holding-plot explanations; mock-scrape and waterhole builds; public-land Pennsylvania hunts; HuntWise topo-feature breakdown.
- National Deer Association / Quality Whitetails archive, including the 2004 Al Brothers Deer Manager of the Year context and early plot-location writing.
- Client-plan breakdown videos posted by landowners who received a WHS design — useful for seeing order of operations on paper.

What this document is not: a reprint of his books, a seed catalog, or permission to treat HuntBrief stand calls as Sturgis calls. The locked HuntBrief terrain engine remains Brad Herndon's map-first choke-point library. Sturgis is the habitat, access, and pressure layer you lay on top of that map.

If the hunter finishes this study and only remembers one line, make it this one:

Make the farm so attractive and the path so obvious that a buck uses the same daylight hallway — then disappear on the downwind edge of that hallway so he never finds out the hallway is a trap.

Pressure first. Access second. Defined movement third. Habitat is the tool, not the trophy.

HuntBrief Field Study · Prepared for Casey Summerlin · Anson County, North Carolina · September 9, 2026